pleaded for continuation of the same armed police protection I'd had, and needed, since birth. I'd never been allowed to go anywhere without three armed bodyguards, even when I was supposedly the most popular member of the family, and now I was the target, along with my wife and son, of unprecedented hate—and the leading proposal under discussion called for total abandonment?

Madness.

I offered to defray the cost of security out of my own pocket. I wasn't sure how I'd do that, but I'd find a way.

I made one last pitch: *Look. Please. Meg and I don't care about perks, we care about working, serving—and staying alive.*

This seemed simple and persuasive. All the heads around the table went up and down.

As the meeting came to a close there was a basic, general agreement. The many fine, granular details of this hybrid arrangement would be sorted out over a twelve-month transitional period, during which we'd continue to have security.

Granny rose. We all rose. She walked out.

For me there was one more piece of unfinished business. I went off to find the office of the Bee. Luckily, I ran into the Queen's friendliest page, who'd always liked me. I asked for directions; he said he'd take me himself. He led me through the kitchen, up some back stairs, down a narrow corridor.

Just that way, he said, pointing.

A few steps later I came upon a huge printer, churning out documents. The Bee's assistant swung into view.

Hello!

I pointed at the printer and said: *This seems to be working fine?*

Yes, Your Royal Highness!

Not broken?

That thing? It's indestructible, sir!

I asked about the printer in the Bee's office. *That one work too?*

Oh, yes, sir! Did you need to print something out?

No, thank you.

I went farther down the corridor, through a door. Everything suddenly looked familiar. Then I remembered. This was the corridor where I'd slept that